UNIVERSITY OF LIVERPOOL | English Language Centre

COMP208: Assessment Support

Session 3: Demo Documentation (CA1)

Session aim

The main aim of this session is to help you to prepare the Demo Documentation (CA1) assignment effectively. We will:

- compare example user manuals to see different ways of organising information for users
- analyse how effective manuals present user types, instructions, and support
- identify useful techniques and language for effective demo video narration
- use marker feedback to identify what makes demo documentation effective

Task 1: Assignment instructions and user manual contents

1. **Consider the assignment guidance on Canvas and discuss the following:**
    1) What are the four elements you need to submit as part of this assignment?
    2) Which types of reader do you need to consider for the written documents?
    3) What kinds of information are likely to be most useful in a user manual?
    4) What does the video need to show, according to the assignment guidance?
    5) What instructions are given about the length and format of the video?

2. **Read the example user manual contents pages (1 - 4) in the additional document and discuss the questions below.**
    1) What do all have in common?
    2) What is different about how each manual is structured?
    3) Is there anything else that you noticed, or which surprised you about the examples?
    4) What ideas could you borrow for your own manual? (e.g. similar sections)

Suggested answers

1. Consider the assignment guidance on Canvas and discuss the following:

1) What are the four elements you need to submit as part of this assignment?
   (1) a video demonstration; (2) a copy of the slides used in the video, (3) if any a one-page access/run document; (4) a user manual document for all different types of users
2) Which types of reader do you need to consider for the written documents?
   markers, who need to access and review the system
   different types of users, who need instructions from the user's perspective
3) What kinds of information are likely to be most useful in a user manual?
   who the different users are; how to install and set up the system; how to use the main features; clear instructions from the user's perspective
4) What does the video need to show, according to the assignment guidance?
   the software in use; the project's aims and challenges; key features through suitable use cases; some internal/system features; any special or interesting features; different user views, if relevant
5) What instructions are given about the length and format of the video?
   it should be no more than 10 minutes; it can use slides and/or screen recording; team members do not need to appear on screen; it should be uploaded as a Canvas Studio video

1) What do all three have in common?
   an introduction / overview section; some form of getting started / quick start / setup; sections explaining how to use the system; support sections such as troubleshooting, FAQ, or glossary; a clear attempt to help the reader navigate the product
2) What is different about how each manual is structured?
   Example 1 is organised mainly by user groups
   Example 2 is organised mainly by workflow and task sequence
   Example 3 is organised mainly by features/pages for one user view
   Example 4 is organised mainly by functions and user tasks, with some step-by-step and interpretation sections

Task 2: Writing Clear Instructions in the Manual

1. **Read the extract below, taken from a health-monitoring app, and discuss the following questions.**
   1) What is the main purpose of this extract?
   2) How is the extract organised to guide the reader?
   3) What language choices make the instructions clear and supportive?
   4) How does the extract help the user complete the task successfully?

Example extract 1

Purpose

This section explains how to complete the assessment form accurately so that the system can generate reliable results.

Steps

1. Open the assessment form from the menu.
2. Enter the required information in each field.
   - Use numbers only in measurement fields.
   - Use recent information where possible.
3. Complete the personal and health questions.
4. Enter the medical measurements requested by the system.
5. Submit the form.

Important notes

- Required fields should be completed before submission.
- The system checks whether values are valid.
- Error messages appear if information is missing or outside the allowed range.
- The form can only be submitted when all entries are valid.

After submission

The system analyses the data and displays the results immediately.

2. **Read the extract again and consider the following.**
   - Find examples of imperative verbs (instructions).
   - Find examples of language that helps the user avoid mistakes or understand what will happen next.

Suggested answers

1) What is the main purpose of this extract?

   to show the user how to complete the assessment form correctly

   to help the user enter information that will produce reliable results

2) How is the extract organised to guide the reader?

   it begins with a clear purpose

   it uses numbered steps in a logical order

   it adds extra guidance through sub-bullets

   it includes important notes before submission

   it explains what happens after submission

3) What language choices make the instructions clear and supportive?

   imperative verbs: open, enter, complete, submit

   clear and simple action-focused sentences

   specific guidance such as “Use numbers only”

   supportive warning/explanation language such as “Error messages appear...”

   clear expected outcome language: “The system analyses the data and displays the results immediately.”

4) How does the extract help the user complete the task successfully?

   it breaks the task into clear steps

   it tells the user what information to enter

   it warns the user about possible mistakes

   it explains validation checks

   it tells the user what will happen next

2. Read the extract again and consider the following.

- Find examples of imperative verbs (instructions).

  Open; enter; use; complete; submit

- Find examples of language that helps the user avoid mistakes or understand what will happen next.

  “Use numbers only in measurement fields.”

  “Use recent information where possible.”

  “Required fields should be completed before submission.”

  “The system checks whether values are valid.”

  “Error messages appear if information is missing or outside the allowed range.”

  “The form can only be submitted when all entries are valid.”

  “The system analyses the data and displays the results immediately.”

3. **Read the extract from Example 2 below, taken from a project about a visual python workflow manager, and discuss the following questions:**
    1. What is the main purpose of this extract?
    2. Who seems to be the intended reader? What suggests this?
    3. How is the extract organised to help the reader?
    4. How does the screenshot support the text? How could it be improved for the reader?

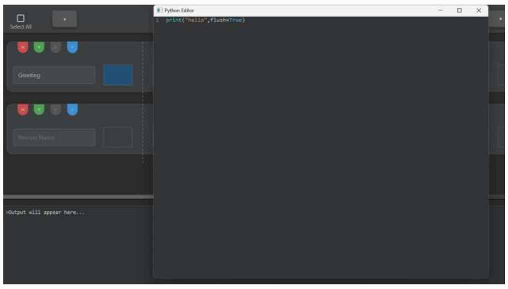
Example extract 2

3.4. Step 3: Adding Code to Blocks

1. Now that we have our two empty process rows, we need to add some code blocks to them! Find the first placeholder block (dashed rectangle) in the top process row and double click on it.

    - The block's appearance will change to a blue colour ("active state")
    - A Python Editor window will pop up

2. Now we have a space we can place some Python code into that box, let's start with something simple like: Print("Hello", flush=True). The flush statement is needed to prevent python itself from buffering print statements (but all code is run in the correct order). It should look like this:



(Note the blue block where you clicked, that has your code in it)

3. once you have added your code, close your editor. Don't worry, your code saves automatically.

4. Repeat this two more times:

- Click on the second box of the second process and add the code print("I love",flush=True)
- Click on the third box of the first process and add the code print("weave! ",flush=True)

4. Read the text again and focus on the language choices made by the writer.

1) Find examples of sequencing language.
2) Find examples of language which tells the reader what to expect or what happens next.
3) How is this extract different from the first one in the way it guides and supports the reader?

Suggested answers

3. **Read the extract from Example 2 below, taken from a project about a visual python workflow manager, and discuss the following questions:**
   1. What is the main purpose of this extract?
      to show the user how to add code to blocks
      to guide the user through one stage of building the workflow
   2. Who seems to be the intended reader? What suggests this?
      a new or inexperienced user; the writer explains basic actions step by step
      the writer explains what the user will see on screen; the tone is reassuring, for example “Don’t worry”
   3. How is the extract organised to help the reader?
      it has a clear step heading; it uses numbered instructions; it adds extra detail with bullet points; it includes a screenshot; it uses a repeat instruction instead of writing the same steps again
   4. How does the screenshot support the text? How could it be improved for the reader?
      it shows the user what the screen should look like; it helps the reader check they are in the right place; it supports the instruction about the blue active block; it makes the task more concrete and easier to follow; but it is not fully labelled, so the reader has to work out some details for themselves

5. **Read the text again and focus on the language choices made by the writer.**
   1) Find examples of sequencing language.
      Now that...; Now we have...; once you have added your code...; Repeat this two more times
   2) Find examples of language which tells the reader what to expect or what happens next.
      “The block’s appearance will change to a blue colour”; “A Python Editor window will pop up”; “It should look like this”; “your code saves automatically”
   3) How is this extract different from the first one in the way it guides and supports the reader?
      it is more informal and conversational; it gives more on-screen guidance; it tells the user more clearly what they will see happen; it uses a more reassuring tone; it relies more on a visual example / screenshot

Task 3: Writing for Different User Types

1. **Read Extract 3 and Extract 4 below and discuss the following questions.**
   1) What user types are identified in these examples?
   2) What kinds of tasks, capabilities, or responsibilities are described for each user type? (Think generally, not specific to this software)
   3) How does each extract make this clear to the reader?
   4) Which approach seems more useful for your own project, and why?

Example extract 3

A. Target Users

This system is designed for two main user groups: **individual users** and **organization users**, each with different roles and system access.

1. Individual Users

These are users who have completed a physical examination and wish to manage their health data and receive risk assessments. They can:

- Upload and manage their examination reports
- View personalized health risk assessments
- Track health trends over time
- Receive tailored health tips and lifestyle suggestions

2. Organization Users

These include community centers, clinics, and health management institutions. They use the system to support group health monitoring and decision-making. They can:

- Import and manage multiple users' health data
- Access health profiles for entire communities
- Export reports for analysis and planning
- Identify and follow up with high-risk individuals

Example extract 4

5.7) Researchers and Academics

Objective	To facilitate research through celestial mechanics simulations.
Activities	**Simulating N-Body Gravitational Problems**: Researchers will use the simulator to investigate complex gravitational interactions. **Collaborating on Research**: Researchers can share their findings and methodologies with peers for feedback and improvement.
Future Enhancements	**Integrating Data Analysis Tools**: Future updates may include tools for computational analysis and the ability to export simulation data.

5.8) Software Developers

Objective	To enhance the simulator's capabilities and expand its features.
Activities	**Modifying Physics Constants**: Developers can adjust physical constants to see how these changes affect simulations. **Introducing New Astronomical Events**: Developers may create simulations of events like black holes or asteroid impacts. **Improving User Interface**: Developers will work on enhancing the user interface to improve usability.
Best Practices	**Version Control**: Developers should use Git to track changes and collaborate efficiently. **Incremental Testing**: After modifications, developers should test the system incrementally to ensure stability.

5.9) Administrators/IT Staff

Objective	To maintain smooth operation and accessibility of the software for all users.
Responsibilities	**Maintaining Java Environments**: Administrators must ensure Java is updated across all devices. **Managing User Access**: Administrators must ensure users can access the appropriate save/load paths. **Troubleshooting Installation Issues**: IT staff should resolve any installation issues that arise.

2. **What features of the writing make these extracts easy to follow, and which of these could work in your own manual?**

Suggested answers

1. **Read Extract 3 and Extract 4 below and discuss the following questions.**
   1) What user types are identified in these examples?

      Extract 3: individual users; organization users

      Extract 4: researchers and academics; software developers; administrators / IT staff
   2) What kinds of tasks, capabilities, or responsibilities are described for each user type?
      - Individual users: manage their own data; view personal results; track changes over time; receive personalised information
      - Organization users: manage multiple users' data; view group-level information; export reports; monitor cases that may need follow-up
      - Researchers and academics: use the system for investigation and analysis; run simulations/tests; work with research data; share or develop findings
      - Software developers: modify and improve system functions; add new features; improve usability; test and manage changes
      - Administrators / IT staff: maintain the system; manage technical settings and access; support smooth operation; troubleshoot problems
   3) How does each extract make this clear to the reader?

      Extract 3 uses clear user-group headings and bullet points

      it explains each group briefly, then lists what they can do

      the structure is simple and easy to scan

      Extract 4 uses separate sections for each user type

      it organises information under labels such as objective, activities, best practices, and responsibilities

      it gives more detailed, role-specific information

      the table layout makes the categories very clear
   4) Which approach seems more useful for your own project, and why?

      Your own answers

2. **What features of the writing make these extracts easy to follow, and which of these could work in your own manual?**

   Your own answers

Task 4: Support sections in user manuals

1. Read the extracts below and discuss the following questions.

1) What kinds of problems, questions, or limits do these extracts address?
2) How do the extracts help the user understand or respond to these issues?
3) What is different about the two approaches?
4) What language or text features make the support clear and useful?

Example extract 5

4. Troubleshooting and FAQ

4.1 Troubleshooting

Issue	Solution
Login fails	ensure you're using a valid Steam account. Ensure correct credentials.
Recommendations not loading	Check your Steam profile/game privacy settings
Website failing to load recommendations	Try at a different time, Steam API has a request limit that may have been reached.
	Check steamstat.us to confirm Steam services are online
Incorrect game prices showing	Game Match caches game pricing data for 24 hours to reduce API load. For real-time pricing, click the "View on Steam" button to see current store prices.
Friends' data missing	Your friend likely has a private profile.
Recommendations seems inaccurate	The algorithm improves with usage, play more games on Steam and invite your friends to use Game Match.
Recent purchases not showing in library	Like incorrect prices, cache only updates once every 24 hours.

Example extract 6

Q: Weave won't start after installing.

A: Make sure you have extracted the **entire** contents of the .zip file, including all the subfolders into one directory.

A: Double check you have **Java 21** or later installed (check on command line *"java -version"*)

A: Try right clicking the weave executable and selecting "Run as administrator"

A: Some anti-virus software will flag the .exe as its not signed, try whitelisting the executable on your anti-virus software.

Suggested answers

1. **Read the extracts below and discuss the following questions.**
    1) What kinds of problems, questions, or limits do these extracts address?

       Extract 5 addresses common user problems, system limits, and expected issues

       examples include login problems, missing data, delayed updates, privacy settings, and inaccurate recommendations

       Extract 6 focuses on one specific installation/start-up problem

       it gives several possible reasons why the software may not start
    2) How do the extracts help the user understand or respond to these issues?

       Extract 5 matches each issue with a short solution or explanation

       it helps the user understand whether the problem is caused by settings, delays, or system limits

       Extract 6 gives several practical actions the user can try

       it helps the user troubleshoot the problem step by step
    3) What is different about the two approaches?

       Extract 5 is a troubleshooting table covering many different issues

       it is brief, scannable, and organised by issue → solution

       Extract 6 is a Q&A / FAQ-style answer to one question

       it gives several possible fixes for the same problem

       Extract 5 is broader; Extract 6 is more focused and detailed
    4) What language or text features make the support clear and useful?

       clear problem-focused headings such as “Login fails”

       direct solution language such as “ensure,” “check,” “try,” “make sure”

       short, practical explanations

       cause-and-effect language that explains why the issue happens

       easy-to-scan formats such as a table and Q/A layout

       multiple possible solutions where one problem may have more than one cause

Task 5: Creating effective video narration

1. **Read the functions and extracts below. Match each extract (A–H) to the function (1–8) it mainly performs in a demo video. An example is given.**

Functions

1. Introducing the project and its purpose **- Answer E**
2. Preparing the viewer for what they are about to see
3. Showing and explaining a feature through a use case
4. Explaining an internal/system feature
5. Highlighting a special feature or design choice
6. Navigating / signposting the walkthrough
7. Explaining a limitation or incomplete feature
8. Explaining a challenge or unmet objective

Extracts

A "Here, you can see my username and my profile picture. Clicking on the username would redirect us to the profile tab, or you can click on the profile tab itself. Moving back you can see my steam ID and view game library which we will go into later."

B "We'll now show two examples of how the system can be used in practice, before moving on to the system's internal features."

C "One of our main aims was to let users create new planets in stable orbit easily. However, one of the biggest challenges we faced was achieving stable orbit creation within a closed solar system."

D "We have two algorithms. We have the matrix SVD and we have the weighted recommendation system, the WRS."

E "Today, we're excited to introduce our project, 2D Solar System Sandbox. Our goal is to create an engaging and educational simulation that makes celestial mechanics accessible and easy to understand." 1. Introducing the project and…

F "For example, by placing 2 similarly sized planets close together but giving them initial velocities, we can simulate a binary star system, demonstrating orbit mechanics first-hand. As you can see, the system updates the graphics in real time and manages physics automatically."

G “Here we have our profile details: ‘account created’, ‘last online’, ‘profile URL’. As you can see, ‘last online’ doesn’t currently work; we’re actively implementing fixes and improving the website.”

H “One of the other exciting features is the procedural generation of asteroid fields. Instead of randomly placing asteroids, we use Perlin noise to create smoother, more realistic distributions.”

2. Discuss the following questions:

1) Which of these functions seem most essential for this assignment, and why?
2) Which functions are more about good practice or presentation quality?
3) What language features make these extracts effective for demo narration?
4) Which ideas could you borrow for your own video?

Suggested answers

1. Introducing the project and its purpose **E**
2. Preparing the viewer for what they are about to see **B**
3. Showing and explaining a feature through a use case **F**
4. Explaining an internal/system feature **D**
5. Highlighting a special feature or design choice **H**
6. Navigating / signposting the walkthrough **A**
7. Explaining a limitation or incomplete feature **G**
8. Explaining a challenge or unmet objective **C**

Extracts

A "Here, you can see my username and my profile picture. Clicking on the username would redirect us to the profile tab, or you can click on the profile tab itself. Moving back you can see my steam ID and view game library which we will go into later." Navigating / signposting the walkthrough

B "We'll now show two examples of how the system can be used in practice, before moving on to the system's internal features." Preparing the viewer for what…

C "One of our main aims was to let users create new planets in stable orbit easily. However, one of the biggest challenges we faced was achieving stable orbit creation within a closed solar system." Explaining a challenge or unmet objective

D "We have two algorithms. We have the matrix SVD and we have the weighted recommendation system, the WRS." Explaining an internal/system feature

E "Today, we're excited to introduce our project, 2D Solar System Sandbox. Our goal is to create an engaging and educational simulation that makes celestial mechanics accessible and easy to understand." Introducing the project and…

F "For example, by placing 2 similarly sized planets close together but giving them initial velocities, we can simulate a binary star system, demonstrating orbit mechanics first-hand. As you can see, the system updates the graphics in real time and manages physics automatically." Showing and explaining a feature…

G "Here we have our profile details: 'account created', 'last online', 'profile URL'. As you can see, 'last online' doesn't currently work; we're actively implementing fixes and improving the website." Explaining a limitation or incomplete feature

H "One of the other exciting features is the procedural generation of asteroid fields. Instead of randomly placing asteroids, we use Perlin noise to create smoother, more realistic distributions." Highlighting a special feature or design choice

2. Discuss the following questions:

1) Which of these functions seem most essential for this assignment, and why?
   - ✓ introducing the project and its purpose
   - ✓ showing and explaining features through use cases
   - ✓ navigating / signposting the walkthrough
   - ✓ explaining some internal/system features
   - ✓ these are most essential because the video needs to show the software in use, explain key features clearly, and help the viewer follow the demo
2) Which functions are more about good practice or presentation quality?
   - preparing the viewer for what they are about to see
   - highlighting a special feature or design choice
   - explaining a limitation or incomplete feature
   - explaining a challenge or unmet objective
   - these help make the video more polished, reflective, and informative
3) What language features make these extracts effective for demo narration?
   - clear signposting language, for example "we'll now show..."
   - language that directs the viewer's attention, for example "here you can see..."
   - present tense to describe what is happening on screen
   - example / use-case language, for example "for example..."
   - clear explanation of purpose, function, or result
   - honest language about limitations or development challenges
4) Which ideas could you borrow for your own video?

   Your own answers

Task 6: Using marker feedback to improve your assignment

The following feedback is taken from real markers from previous years. The comments are from a range of different projects.

1. **Read the feedback comments below and discuss the following questions.**
    1) What impressed the markers, what do they value in the manuals and videos?
    2) What weakness or problems do they identify?
    3) What are three practical points your group need to remember for this assignment?

1) “Excellent. Well organized video presentation. Very good use of the available time. Never boring, or repetitive. Informative, and comprehensive.”
   Relates to: Video, Presentation quality; Grade: A

2) “Excellent. Examples are informative without being too convoluted.”
   Relates to: Video, Examples; Grade: A

3) “Much of the demo was the accompanying slides. It would have been more useful to spend a bit more time on the software demonstration and show it actually carrying out some tasks.”
   Relates to: Video, Presentation quality; Grade: C

4) “A demo should show the app actually working.”
   Relates to: Video; Grade: Examples = E+, Main aspects shown = C

5) “Outstanding description of the features offered to different users. Very detailed, clear, comprehensive.”
   Relates to: Manual, User oriented views; Grade: A+

6) “Comprehensive instructions covering wide range of users.”
   Relates to: Manual, User oriented views; Grade: A+

7) “There wasn't much in the way of user instruction in the manual.”
   Relates to: Manual, How to Use instructions; Grade: D

8) “Adequate, if basic, user instructions.”
   Relates to: Manual, How to Use instructions; Grade: D

Suggested answers

1. Read the feedback comments below and discuss the following questions.

1) What impressed the marker's, what do they value in the manuals and videos?

   clear organisation

   good use of time in the video

   informative but not over-complicated examples

   videos that show the software actually working

   clear, detailed, and comprehensive manuals

   strong attention to different user types

   instructions that are useful for a range of users

2) What weakness or problems do they identify?

   too much time spent on slides

   not enough live software demonstration

   not showing the app carrying out tasks

   weak or limited user instructions

   instructions that are only basic

3) What are three practical points your group need to remember for this assignment?

   Your answers